

Technical Support for Rural Startups

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT PROGRAM (CEP) REPORT · B.Sc. IT, AY 2025–26

1. Background

The Community Engagement Program (CEP) bridges classroom learning with community needs. This initiative provided hands-on digital interventions to micro-businesses near Kolhapur, Maharashtra, pairing Information Technology students directly with local entrepreneurs.

2. Objectives

- Assess the digital readiness of each participating enterprise.
- Provide direct technical training in UPI, WhatsApp Business, Google Business Profile, and Excel-based inventory tracking.
- Evaluate real adoption outcomes through a follow-up visit.

3. Methodology

- 1 **Visit 1 — Needs Assessment & Interviews:** Baseline operational review.
- 2 **Visit 2 — Hands-on Onboarding:** Setting up UPI, WhatsApp catalogue, Google Business Profile, and sales/inventory spreadsheets.
- 3 **Visit 3 — Follow-Up & Review:** One-week follow-up to address friction points and review usage.

4. Field Visit Records

Startup	Founder	Village	Support Provided
Sunrise Agro Foods	Sunita Patil	Vadgaon, Kolhapur	UPI, WhatsApp Business, Google Listing, Excel Tracker, Cybers
Kalamandir Handicrafts	Ramesh Chavan	Panhala, Kolhapur	UPI, WhatsApp Catalogue, Google Listing, Fraud Awareness

5. Conclusion

Direct, hands-on support overcame the initial hesitation that no pamphlet or one-off workshop could. Follow-up visits proved essential to sustaining new digital habits beyond the first demonstration. Most importantly, interventions succeeded when they matched each enterprise's existing record-keeping habits rather than trying to replace them outright.

Prepared by B.Sc. Information Technology students, Academic Year 2025–26, Department of Information Technology, under faculty guidance.